IBAD-MUN 2026 | DELEGATE TRAINING SESSION

Mandate of UNGA, UNHRC and UNSC

and Their Legal Status

Binding / Non-Binding

UNGA
Non-binding

UNHRC
Non-binding

UNSC
Binding

Presented by
Ashfaque

INTRODUCTION

Before We Begin

Why mandate and authority matter

Before we begin discussing the procedures of our committees, it is important for every delegate to understand the **mandate** and **authority** of the committee in which they are participating.

Every United Nations committee has a specific purpose. It has certain responsibilities, certain powers, and certain limitations.

For example, the **General Assembly** deals with international cooperation and global issues, the **Human Rights Council** focuses on protecting human rights, while the **Security Council** is responsible for maintaining international peace and security.

Another important distinction is whether the decisions of these committees are **legally binding** or **non-binding**.

Let’s understand each committee separately.

> TWO KEY IDEAS
>
> **Mandate = what a committee is for.**
> **Legal status = whether its decisions must be obeyed.**

COMMITTEE 01

UNGA

United Nations General Assembly

NON-BINDING

UNGA stands for **United Nations General Assembly**.

It is one of the principal organs of the United Nations, and all **193 UN member states** are represented in it.

The main mandate of UNGA is to discuss international issues, promote cooperation between countries, and recommend possible solutions to global problems.

These problems can include climate change, poverty, education, international development, economic inequality, and international security.

For example, consider our own UNGA agenda: **combating climate change through international cooperation**. Delegates can discuss how countries should cooperate, how developed countries can support developing countries financially, how renewable energy can be promoted, and how climate-vulnerable countries can be protected.

However, there is one important limitation. UNGA generally cannot force a country to follow its recommendations. It can propose solutions, encourage cooperation, and adopt resolutions, but its ordinary recommendations are **not legally binding** on member states.

REMEMBER

UNGA discusses international problems and recommends international solutions.

COMMITTEE 02

UNHRC

United Nations Human Rights Council

NON-BINDING

Now let's move towards our second committee, UNHRC, which stands for **United Nations Human Rights Council**.

Its main mandate is to promote and protect human rights around the world.

What does that actually mean? It means that UNHRC addresses issues such as discrimination, racism, religious intolerance, freedom of speech, women's rights, children's rights, socioeconomic inequality, and violations of fundamental human rights.

For example, if people in a country are facing discrimination because of their religion, ethnicity, gender, or social background, this is the kind of issue that UNHRC can discuss.

The Council can investigate human rights situations through its mechanisms, establish commissions of inquiry, appoint independent experts, monitor human rights conditions, and make recommendations to governments.

But does UNHRC have the authority to directly punish a country or force its government to change its laws? Generally, no.

Its resolutions and recommendations are not legally binding on states. It mainly works through investigation, international pressure, recommendations, monitoring, and cooperation. However, countries may still have binding obligations under international human rights treaties they have ratified.

REMEMBER

UNHRC protects human rights, addresses violations, investigates situations, and recommends improvements.

COMMITTEE 03

UNSC

United Nations Security Council

LEGALLY BINDING

Now we come to our third committee, the UNSC, which stands for **United Nations Security Council**. Unlike UNGA and UNHRC, the Security Council has a very different level of authority.

Its primary mandate is to maintain **international peace and security**. For example, imagine two countries are involved in a military conflict, or a situation develops that threatens international peace. The Security Council can discuss the situation and take measures to address the threat.

These measures can include demanding a ceasefire, imposing economic sanctions, establishing or authorizing peacekeeping operations, and, in certain circumstances, authorizing the use of military force.

The Security Council has **15 members**: five permanent members and ten non-permanent members.

Now comes the most important difference.

Unlike UNGA and UNHRC, the UNSC can adopt **legally binding decisions**. When the Security Council adopts a decision that is binding under the UN Charter, member states are legally obligated to accept and carry it out. For example, under **Chapter VII** of the UN Charter, the Security Council can impose sanctions on a country, and UN member states are required to implement those binding decisions.

However, not every UNSC resolution is automatically binding. It depends on the nature and legal basis of the decision.

REMEMBER

UNSC maintains international peace and security and has the authority to make legally binding decisions.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Three Situations

Which committee handles what?

Now that we have understood all three committees, let's make the difference very simple. Imagine three different situations.

If the world is facing a **climate crisis**, which committee would discuss international cooperation and recommend climate solutions?	**UNGA**
If people are facing **discrimination, human rights violations, or inequality**, which committee would address these problems?	**UNHRC**
If two countries are involved in a **conflict that threatens international peace and security**, which committee has the authority to take security-related measures?	**UNSC**

The final distinction you must remember

UNGA	Generally **non-binding**
UNHRC	Generally **non-binding**
UNSC	Can make **legally binding** decisions, particularly under Chapter VII of the UN Charter

This difference is important because every committee has its own jurisdiction and authority. As delegates, you should make sure that your proposals and resolutions remain within the mandate of your respective committee.

Thank you.

SUMMARY

At a Glance

Mandate and legal status of each committee

UNGA

United Nations General Assembly

NON-BINDING

International cooperation

- Discusses global issues.
- Recommends international solutions.
- Promotes cooperation between countries.

UNHRC

United Nations Human Rights Council

NON-BINDING

Human rights protection

- Addresses human rights violations.
- Investigates and monitors situations.
- Recommends improvements to governments.

UNSC

United Nations Security Council

LEGALLY BINDING

International peace and security

- Addresses international conflicts.
- Can impose sanctions.
- Can authorize peacekeeping measures and, in certain circumstances, military force.